

Buying PEACE

Manmohan pacifies his party and the Opposition by reverting to the old template on Pakistan

By Saurabh Shukla

It was a political and diplomatic tremor early in his second term for Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. And in the aftermath of the controversial Sharm el-Sheikh Indo-Pak joint statement, he tried to buy peace with both, the critics in his own party and an aggressive Opposition, by reverting back to the time-tested stand of not having a "meaningful dialogue" with Pakistan till it kept its commitment on curbing terror.

As the prime minister began to douse the fire in Parliament, he also flagged his personal conviction to engage with Pakistan, stating that "dialogue and engagement is the best way forward". But he could do little to clear the air over how he miscalculated on the joint statement with Pakistan and who was responsible for the bungle over mentioning Balochistan. As Yashwant Sinha, who led the BJP's attack in Parliament, put it, "All the waters of Neptune will not wash the shame of Sharm el-Sheikh."

The prime minister claimed that he let Balochistan be mentioned in the joint statement as India has nothing to hide. But Manmohan's replies fell short of undoing the damage at Sharm el-Sheikh. Pakistan's response after the meeting indicates that the B-word is here to stay in the lexicon of India's engagement with Pakistan and as Sinha pointed out, would continue to haunt him and India's foreign policy at every international forum. Pakistan is likely to raise it when the foreign secretaries meet soon.

Manmohan responded politically to the accusations made by opposition



leaders that the foundations of India's foreign policy had cracked during his Egyptian trip by training his guns at the NDA and saying that he didn't need lessons from the Opposition. He then taunted them by saying that his Government has achieved much more than the NDA managed to achieve from Pakistan. Manmohan referred to his trophy—a 34-page dossier that India received prior to his departure for the NAM Summit that admitted that Pakistan-based group Lashkar-e-Toiba (LET) was behind the Mumbai at-

tacks and even provided details on how the plot was hatched as well as photographs of those accused in the attacks under detention in Pakistan.

The prime minister went on to say that this is the first time that Pakistan had admitted to the involvement of its nationals, and this is for the first time that India has been updated on the probe into a terror attack in India. While Pakistan may have been more responsive this time, this has little to do with a change of heart and more because Pakistani national Ajmal



“ The pillars of Indian foreign policy have broken. All the waters of Neptune will not wash the shame of Sharm el-Sheikh. ”

YASHWANT SINHA, BJP MP, Former foreign minister